

SLAVES, QUEENS, AND pharaohs

ANCIENT EGYPT

The people of ancient Egypt had a deeprooted religious perspective on life. They believed in the concept of ma'at—meaning “order” or “balance”—which was embodied by the goddess of the same name. Ma'at maintained the masculine and feminine aspects of the universe in perfect balance. In Egyptian society, women were therefore seen as almost equal to men, even if they were not always treated as such.

Powerful goddesses

Egyptians worshipped many different gods and goddesses, each seen as being responsible for a different aspect of life. The variety of strong goddesses influenced the range of roles that women filled; people respected or feared their goddesses, and women aspired to have similar qualities. Hathor, often shown with a cow's head, was the goddess of fertility and

love. Fierce, lion-headed Sekhmet was a goddess of war, and was at times regarded as another aspect of Hathor's nurturing character. Isis was a healer as well as an ideal wife and mother—the crucial roles for women at the time—and so served as a shining example for all women.

Women's rights

Egyptian women, particularly those in the upper classes, could own and pass on property, and own businesses, as well as initiate divorces or other legal proceedings, and serve as witnesses in court cases. The majority of women married and ran a household, often working the land as well; a married woman was called “mistress of the house.” Some women performed roles outside the home, as priestesses, or as managers of textile workshops and breweries. In the clergy,

► Status of slaves

Egyptian slaves were given more than common peasants. They received security, housing, food, and did not pay taxes. This wall painting from the chapel of Nebamun, a wealthy scribe, shows slave girls entertaining guests at a feast.

